

UNIT 2:

Literature Review and Theoretical Framework

2.1 Literature Survey

Concept

A literature survey, also called a literature review, is the process of systematically finding, reading, evaluating, and summarizing existing published work related to your research topic. It is done before starting your actual data collection.

The literature survey is not just a list of what others have said. It is a critical analysis of existing knowledge. A good literature review identifies patterns, contradictions, gaps, and debates in the existing research. It connects that existing work to your own study.

Think of it this way: before building a new house, you study the land, the existing structures around it, and the best building methods. A literature review does the same thing for your research.

Purposes of a Literature Survey

- **Understanding the field:** It gives you a strong background in the topic before you begin. You learn the major theories, key studies, and current debates.

- **Avoiding duplication:** It shows what has already been studied so you can make sure your research adds something new rather than repeating what has already been done.
- **Identifying gaps:** Most literature reviews reveal areas that have not been studied enough. Your research can fill one of those gaps.
- **Building a theoretical foundation:** The literature review provides the theoretical framework that guides your study.
- **Refining the research problem:** Reading existing studies often helps you narrow and clarify your own research question.
- **Justifying your research:** You can use the literature review to show why your research is needed and what it will contribute.
- **Developing the hypothesis:** Evidence from past studies helps you form a well grounded hypothesis.

Steps in Conducting a Literature Survey

Step 1: Identify your topic and key concepts Start with your broad research topic and break it down into key concepts and keywords. For example, if your topic is "effect of training on performance," your keywords might be "employee training," "job performance," "skill development," "human resource development."

Step 2: Search for relevant sources Use libraries, online academic databases, search engines, and institutional repositories to find books, journal articles, research reports, and theses related to your keywords.

Step 3: Screen sources for relevance You will find many sources. Read the title and abstract first. Only go deeper into sources that are clearly relevant to your topic. Prioritize recent sources (last 5 to 10 years) and peer reviewed journals.

Step 4: Read and take notes Read selected sources carefully. Take notes on key findings, theories, methods used, conclusions, and limitations. Note the author, year, and publication for citation purposes.

Step 5: Critically evaluate sources Not all sources are equally trustworthy. Ask: Who wrote this? Is it published in a reputable journal? When was it published? Is the methodology sound? Are the conclusions supported by the evidence?

Step 6: Organize and synthesize Group sources by theme, theory, or argument. Look for what different authors agree on, where they disagree, and what questions remain unanswered.

Step 7: Write the literature review Write a coherent narrative that connects existing knowledge to your research problem. Do not just summarize each source one by one. Analyze and synthesize across sources.

2.2 Literature Search Through the Internet

The internet has transformed how researchers find sources. You no longer need to visit a physical library to find academic work. However, not all online sources are reliable, so researchers must be careful and selective.

Reliable Online Academic Sources

- **Google Scholar (scholar.google.com):** The most widely used free academic search engine. It indexes millions of academic papers, theses, books, and conference proceedings.
- **ResearchGate (researchgate.net):** A platform where researchers share their papers. You can often download full text articles for free.

- **JSTOR (jstor.org):** A digital library with thousands of academic journals and books. Some content is free, some requires subscription.
- **Semantic Scholar:** An AI powered academic search engine that finds relevant papers based on concepts, not just keywords.
- **PubMed:** Mainly for health sciences but useful if your business research overlaps with health topics.
- **Nepal Journals Online (nepjol.info):** A database of Nepali academic journals. Very useful for finding local research relevant to Nepal.
- **University library portals:** Many universities subscribe to databases like EBSCO, ProQuest, and Emerald Insight. If you have university access, use these for high quality peer reviewed articles.
- **Government websites:** CBS Nepal (Central Bureau of Statistics), Nepal Rastra Bank, Ministry websites for official reports and data.

Tips for Effective Internet Literature Search

- Use specific and relevant keywords rather than broad general terms.
- Use Boolean operators to refine results:
 - AND narrows the search (employee training AND performance)
 - OR broadens the search (training OR learning AND performance)
 - NOT excludes a term (training NOT sports)
- Put exact phrases in quotation marks to search for that exact combination of words.
- Filter results by publication year to get recent studies.
- Look for the "Cite" button on Google Scholar to get properly formatted references.
- Check the credibility of any source before using it. Look at the author's credentials, the journal's reputation, and the publication date.

- Avoid using Wikipedia, random blogs, or unverified websites as academic sources. You can use them for background reading but not as references in your work.

2.3 Theoretical Framework

What is a Theoretical Framework?

A theoretical framework is the conceptual structure that underpins your research. It is built from existing theories, models, and concepts that are relevant to your research problem. It shows the key variables you are studying, the relationships between them, and the theoretical basis for those expected relationships.

Think of the theoretical framework as a map for your research. It shows where you are starting, where you are going, and what path you will follow. Without this map, your research has no clear direction.

Why is a Theoretical Framework Important?

- It gives your research a solid academic foundation by connecting it to established theory.
- It helps you identify exactly what to measure and how.
- It guides the formation of your hypothesis.
- It makes your research credible because it is grounded in existing knowledge.
- It provides a framework for interpreting your results. When you get results, you interpret them in the light of the theory you used.

How to Build a Theoretical Framework

1. Identify the key variables in your research (independent, dependent, moderating).
2. Review existing theories that explain the relationship between these variables.
3. Choose the theory or theories most relevant to your research.
4. Clearly state what relationship you expect between your variables and why, based on the theory.
5. Present the framework visually if possible (a diagram showing variables and their connections).

Example

A researcher is studying the effect of leadership style on employee motivation in Nepali banks.

The researcher reads about two relevant theories:

- **Transformational Leadership Theory:** Leaders who inspire and motivate employees produce higher levels of commitment and performance.
- **Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs:** People are motivated when their needs are fulfilled.

Based on these theories, the theoretical framework would show:

- Independent variable: Leadership style (transformational vs transactional)
- Dependent variable: Employee motivation
- Expected relationship: Transformational leadership positively affects employee motivation

2.4 Research Problem

What is a Research Problem?

A research problem is the specific issue, gap, question, or concern that a research study is designed to investigate. It is the starting point of any research project. Without a clearly defined problem, research has no purpose.

A research problem is not just something that is wrong. It can also be a question that has not been answered yet, a gap in existing knowledge, a contradiction between what theory predicts and what practice shows, or a practical management challenge.

Where Do Research Problems Come From?

- Gaps identified while reading existing literature
- Real world problems observed in organizations
- Contradictions or inconsistencies in existing research findings
- Questions left unanswered by previous studies
- Changes in the environment that need investigation (new technology, new laws, market shifts)
- Suggestions from practitioners or industry professionals

Characteristics of a Good Research Problem

- **Clear and specific:** It is stated precisely and does not leave room for confusion. A vague problem leads to vague research.
- **Researchable:** It can actually be studied using available methods and within realistic constraints.

- **Significant:** It is worth investigating. The answer should matter to someone (managers, policymakers, academics).
- **Feasible:** It can be completed within the available time, budget, and access to data.
- **Ethical:** It can be studied without harming people or violating their rights.
- **Novel:** It adds something new to existing knowledge rather than simply repeating past studies.

How to State a Research Problem

A research problem is usually stated in two to three sentences that:

1. Describe the general context or background
2. Point out the specific gap, issue, or question
3. Explain why this needs investigation

Example: "Employee turnover in the banking sector of Nepal has been rising steadily over the past five years. However, most existing studies on turnover have focused on Western countries and their findings may not apply to the Nepali context. The specific factors driving turnover in Nepali commercial banks remain poorly understood."

This statement clearly identifies what is known, what is not known, and why new research is needed.

2.5 Statement of Research Objectives

Research objectives are specific, clear statements of what the research intends to achieve. They translate the broad research problem into concrete, actionable goals.

Types of Research Objectives

General (Main) Objective: This is the overall purpose of the study stated in one sentence. It describes the main thing the research wants to achieve.

Example: "To examine the factors affecting employee turnover in commercial banks of Nepal."

Specific Objectives: These break the main objective into smaller, focused sub goals. Each specific objective targets one particular aspect of the research problem. Together, they cover all aspects of the main objective.

Example specific objectives:

- To identify the demographic profile of employees who have left the banking sector in the past three years.
- To examine the relationship between salary satisfaction and employee turnover intention.
- To analyze the role of work environment in influencing turnover decisions.
- To assess the impact of career development opportunities on employee retention.

How to Write Good Research Objectives

- Start with an action verb: to identify, to analyze, to examine, to assess, to compare, to determine, to describe, to evaluate.
- Each objective should address one specific aspect. Do not combine two ideas in one objective.
- Objectives should be measurable. You should be able to tell at the end of the research whether each objective was achieved.

- Objectives should be realistic given your time, resources, and access.
- Objectives should align directly with the research problem. Do not include objectives that are unrelated to the problem.

2.6 Formulation of Research Hypothesis

What is a Hypothesis?

A hypothesis is a specific, testable prediction about the expected relationship between two or more variables. It is an educated guess based on theory, logic, and existing research. The purpose of much research is to test whether the hypothesis is supported or rejected by the data.

A hypothesis is not a random guess. It must have a logical or theoretical basis. You must be able to explain why you expect that particular relationship.

Types of Hypothesis

Null Hypothesis (H_0): The null hypothesis states that there is no significant relationship or difference between the variables. It is the default position that the researcher challenges. Statistical testing is designed to try to reject the null hypothesis.

Example: "There is no significant relationship between employee training and job performance."

Alternative Hypothesis (H_1): The alternative hypothesis states what the researcher actually expects to find. It proposes that a relationship or difference exists. When the null hypothesis is rejected, the alternative hypothesis is supported.

Example: "Employee training has a positive and significant effect on job performance."

Types Based on Direction:

- **Directional hypothesis:** Specifies not only that a relationship exists but also its direction (positive or negative).
 - Example: "Higher advertising expenditure leads to higher sales revenue."
- **Non directional hypothesis:** States that a relationship or difference exists but does not specify its direction.
 - Example: "There is a significant relationship between advertising expenditure and sales revenue."

Characteristics of a Good Hypothesis

- **Clear and concise:** Stated in simple, direct language.
- **Testable:** Can be examined using available data and methods.
- **Based on theory or logic:** Not a random guess. There should be a reason to expect that relationship.
- **Specific:** Mentions the variables and the expected relationship clearly.
- **Falsifiable:** It is possible for the data to show that the hypothesis is wrong. If a hypothesis cannot be proven wrong under any circumstances, it is not useful scientifically.

2.7 Research Approaches: Deduction and Induction

Research approaches describe the logical process by which researchers move between theory and data. The two main approaches are deduction and induction.

Understanding these is important because they determine the overall logic of your research.

Deductive Approach

The deductive approach starts with a theory or general principle and moves toward specific data to test that theory. It works from the top down: from general to specific.

In deductive research:

1. The researcher starts with an existing theory.
2. Based on the theory, they develop a specific hypothesis.
3. They design a study to test the hypothesis.
4. They collect data.
5. They analyze the data to see if it supports or rejects the hypothesis.
6. Based on the results, the original theory is confirmed, revised, or rejected.

Example: Theory: According to Herzberg's Two Factor Theory, salary alone does not motivate employees. Intrinsic factors like recognition and achievement are the real motivators.

Hypothesis: Employees who receive regular recognition will show higher job satisfaction than those who receive only high salaries without recognition.

The researcher then surveys 300 employees, collects data, and tests this hypothesis statistically.

Key features of deductive approach:

- Moves from general theory to specific data
- Tests existing theories
- Uses quantitative methods mostly
- More structured and controlled
- Associated with positivist paradigm
- Allows generalization if proper sampling is used

Inductive Approach

The inductive approach starts with specific observations and moves upward to develop general theory. It works from the bottom up: from specific to general.

In inductive research:

1. The researcher starts with no pre-existing theory or hypothesis.
2. They collect data through observation, interviews, or other qualitative methods.
3. They look for patterns and themes in the data.
4. From those patterns, they develop a general theory or conceptual framework.

Example: A researcher interviews 25 small business owners in rural Nepal about how they manage their businesses. After analyzing the interviews, recurring themes emerge: reliance on family networks, distrust of formal financial institutions, and decisions based on community norms. From these themes, the researcher develops a new theory about informal business management in rural Nepali contexts.

Key features of inductive approach:

- Moves from specific observations to general theory
- Builds new theories rather than testing existing ones
- Uses qualitative methods mostly
- More flexible and open ended
- Associated with interpretivist paradigm
- Findings are context specific

Comparison:

Aspect	Deductive	Inductive
Direction	General to specific	Specific to general
Starting point	Existing theory	Observations or data
Ending point	Confirmed or rejected hypothesis	New theory
Methods used	Mainly quantitative	Mainly qualitative
Paradigm	Positivism	Interpretivism
Flexibility	Less flexible	More flexible
Risk	Theory may not fit real life	May result in weak theories

Many modern researchers use both approaches in the same study. This is called an **abductive approach**, where the researcher moves back and forth between theory and data.